

Building a sand castle!

A mallee bird doesn't build a nest, it makes a massive mound. It piles leaves into a pit and covers them with sand. The rotting leaves give off heat and incubate the eggs.

The chicks will dig their way out.

Sand is scraped away if the eggs overheat.



Sandy birds

Pale-colored feathers reflect the sun's heat and are good desert camouflage.

Gila woodpeckers peck away dead bits of cactus as they hunt for insects.

This Western bluebird is keeping cool in a shady bush.

Gambel's quail search under stones for seeds and scorpions.



This little elf owl is taking shelter from the scorching sun in a hole made by a gila woodpecker.

Tiny verdin hang upside down from cactus branches to look for insects.

Cactus wrens have scaly legs and tough feathers to protect them from the cactus spines.

